

Chapter 124-1

Winter in Haizhou City was shorter than other seasons.

The biting winds of late autumn had been blowing for a long time, yet true winter still hadn't arrived. The continuous autumn rains had fallen several times, each followed by drops in temperature that would then rise again.

Just like riding a roller coaster.

Even though, according to the solar terms, it was already early winter.

Last night's wind wasn't unfounded¹—after a night of wind, rain indeed fell by evening. The red clouds spreading across the distant horizon were instantly covered by dark clouds. The change in the sky was just a matter of an instant.

The wind kept blowing against the windows, making the bare trees outside sway back and forth.

Liang Shi didn't bother with the shattered glass at her feet. She kept enlarging the picture, again and again.

—Rumble.

The sudden flash of light tore a huge gash in the dim sky, as if trying to swallow the entire mortal world into its belly. Accompanying it was deafening thunder.

The wind blew the window open, making Liang Shi's back turn ice cold.

To be precise, her entire body was ice cold.

In the photo, Xu Qingzhu's eyes were covered with black cloth, her hands bound behind her back with thick hemp rope, and her mouth was taped with black tape. She was wearing the same clothes she had worn when leaving in the morning, only now they were stained with dirt.

Xu Qingzhu's feet were bound together with black electrical cord, looking as if they had been tied with whatever was at hand.

She was curled up in a corner, her head drooping limply, as if unconscious.

The wicked wind and cold rain made her mood even worse. In a moment of panic and chaos, she made a video call to Xu Qingzhu.

But the other side hung up immediately.

A three-second voice message came from there, the voice processed through a voice changer: "Do you want to save her?"

Liang Shi was about to call the police when another voice message came: "Then come to the address I give you. If you call the police, I'll kill her right now."

What followed was a short video.

In the video, Xu Qingzhu still showed no reaction, but a sharp knife was pressed against her cheek. The silver blade contrasted with her skin tone, making one's heart pound with fear, dreading the sight of blood.

The other party sent an address—in the outskirts of Haizhou City.

That entire area hadn't been demolished yet. The Haizhou city government planned to develop it heavily in a few years, supposedly to build a new amusement park and shopping mall.

But right now, it was a desolate wasteland.

Liang Shi knew about this place because Xu Qingzhu had told her. Xu Qingzhu had said that if she wanted to invest in property, she could wait for houses in that area—there should be great potential for appreciation.

Voice messages kept coming.

"She hasn't woken up yet. Do you think if I slowly torture her here, will it trigger her PTSD?"

"She seems to be afraid of having her eyes covered, did you know?"

"If you want her to live, then do as I say obediently."

"Come to the address I sent within one hour, otherwise... what you'll see when you arrive will definitely be a corpse."

"Or maybe a naked body. Hehe."

Five consecutive voice messages, the tone becoming increasingly outrageous. Listening to them made Liang Shi clench her fists.

Her originally groggy mind was now completely clear, yet it was constantly being clouded by anger. She wished she could reach through the internet and beat this person to death.

But after the tremendous anger subsided, Liang Shi pressed on her phone screen and tried to negotiate with the other party as calmly as possible: "What do you want? Money?"

"Or do you want revenge on me? Then come at me directly. I can exchange myself for her."

"If you want revenge on me, then you should kidnap me, torture me, kill me—that would be more satisfying. What's the point of kidnapping a stranger?"

"How much money do you want?"

The intervals between Liang Shi's voice messages weren't short. She tried her best to maintain calm thoughts to think through this matter.

She also tried not to let the other party discover how important Xu Qingzhu was to her.

Although her "trying her best" was also a barely controllable effort.

Her fingernails pressing on the phone screen had turned white. Her face, which had been slightly flushed from grogginess earlier, was now pale as paper—a shocking sight.

Yet Liang Shi didn't notice.

She kept guessing who the kidnapper was, and what purpose they had in kidnapping Xu Qingzhu.

If the other party wanted to kill the hostage, they could have just killed Xu Qingzhu directly. But now they were contacting her through Xu Qingzhu's WeChat, which meant they had other intentions?

They hadn't mentioned money at all, only specifically asked her to come—for what purpose?

Revenge against her?

The original owner had offended so many people, so this possibility couldn't be ruled out.

But how did the other party know that Xu Qingzhu had PTSD?

In just a few short minutes, a storm raged through Liang Shi's mind.

She searched through possible people in her head, and ultimately could only think of one—Chen Liuying.

Footnotes:

¹ **Not unfounded (空穴來風):** This is a Chinese idiom that literally means "wind coming from an empty cave." It refers to rumors or occurrences that have some basis in reality—where there's smoke, there's fire. The original text had a typo (空xue來風) which has been corrected in translation.

Chapter 124-2

Just as Liang Shi was about to send a voice message to confirm, another message came from the other party, the voice processed through a voice changer: "If you call the police now, I'll make sure you receive Xu Qingzhu's memorial photo."

Liang Shi didn't dare take the risk. She didn't even have time to change clothes—she just switched to a pair of comfortable flat shoes and hurried out the door.

Outside was a torrential downpour, which matched the strong wind perfectly.

The violent wind and rain even carried tree branches onto the road. Liang Shi glanced at the navigation—it would still take forty-nine minutes to get there, and that was the shortest distance, not accounting for traffic.

After driving for a while, Liang Shi's mind finally wasn't a chaotic mess anymore, and she could spare some mental space to think about this matter.

She didn't dare use the phone number the other party had contacted her with to make calls. Instead, she switched to a phone number she had never used before and called Zhao Xuning.

Zhao Xuning's side was slow to answer, but she finally picked up.

Her voice was hoarse and carried impatience—obvious signs of being woken up. Liang Shi hadn't expected her to be sleeping at this hour, but since the call had gone through, Zhao Xuning was the only person she could trust right now.

"You'd better have something important." Zhao Xuning said through gritted teeth.

Liang Shi ignored her grumpiness from being woken up. Her foot on the accelerator was trembling, her entire body was cold, yet she persisted through sheer bodily instinct. Although her voice was shaking, every word was bitten out with exceptional clarity: "Zhao Xuning, listen to me."

"Near Provincial Road 209 on Xihui Road, in the former abandoned chemical factory not far from the highway exit, a kidnapping has occurred. The kidnapped victim is a woman. The kidnapper threatened to kill her if the police are called, so the police can depart ten minutes from now. Please make sure the police turn off their sirens and quietly set up a perimeter around the area."

Liang Shi was maintaining maximum rationality as she spoke to Zhao Xuning. "Once they hear an alarm sound from inside, I hope the police will move in immediately. I will do my best to cooperate from inside. The nature of this kidnapping case seems more like revenge than robbery, so I will try my best to stall the kidnapper and buy time for the police to set up."

She said all this in one breath. Zhao Xuning on the other end of the phone was stunned for a moment, then quickly reacted: "Xu Qingzhu was kidnapped?"

Liang Shi's voice trembled: "Yes, I'm on my way to rescue her—though I might just be walking into a trap. That's why I think we still need to call the police."

It wasn't that her combat ability wasn't high enough; the most important thing was that Xu Qingzhu was in the other party's hands.

And also...

Liang Shi said coldly: "Also, the kidnapper is very likely the washed-up celebrity Chen Liuying. You can track this phone of mine now so you'll be able to pinpoint my location, but you need to be quick. If possible, please have the police check Chen Liuying's travel history, especially any records of her appearing near Minghui Jewelry. Of course, it's best not to leak the information that Xu Qingzhu has been kidnapped, otherwise it will affect Minghui Jewelry if it gets out."

That was Xu Qingzhu's life's work. Liang Shi wanted to protect it for her.

After hearing all this, all of Zhao Xuning's grumpiness from being woken up vanished completely. She simply reminded her: "Be careful in all things."

Liang Shi responded with an "mm."

Zhao Xuning said: "I'll take care of all these things for you."

Liang Shi said in a muffled voice: "Thank you."

There was even a hint of tragic heroism in her tone.

It was precisely because she trusted Zhao Xuning that Liang Shi chose to call her.

Zhao Xuning's network of connections here was much stronger than hers, so having Zhao Xuning handle this would be far more efficient than doing it herself.

After hanging up the phone, Liang Shi happened to turn a corner. Ahead was a wide-open road. She stepped on the accelerator and sped forward.

The windshield wipers kept scraping across the glass. The sky was growing darker. The fine threads of rain looked especially desolate under the dim yellow streetlights. The car kept passing by other vehicles.

Gradually disappearing from sight.

Chapter 124-3

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Endless, boundless darkness, even her head felt heavy and stuffy.

There was the smell of freshly turned earth—it must be raining.

Yet in this endless darkness, she seemed to hear the sound of ocean waves rolling. For a moment, she even thought she had arrived at the seaside.

Her body was limp and powerless, her eyelids felt like they weighed a thousand pounds and wouldn't open no matter what.

Xu Qingzhu heard rustling sounds but couldn't distinguish what was making the noise.

Even though she was dressed warmly enough, she still felt cold in this environment.

She sniffled and could smell the damp, briny scent in the air—very much like the smell of the sea, yet not as strong.

Every time it rained heavily in Haizhou City, this smell would appear in the air.

Xu Qingzhu used all her strength to barely open her eyes, but her body had no strength at all. She was like a soft ball of cotton—even if someone punched her, she wouldn't react.

Both her body and head were groggy and muddled—it must be the effect of drugs.

Her nape felt a dull ache, especially the patch of skin at the back of her neck, which seemed to have no sensation, just like being given anesthesia before surgery.

But this anesthetic probably contained more than just painkillers—there was something else making her unable to exert any strength.

Also, her back was being pressed against something hard and painful, and she could feel coldness and dampness.

Even though she had struggled with all her might to open her eyes, everything before her was still pitch black.

Her mouth was also taped shut, sealed tightly. Her hands and feet were all bound. If she wanted to move now, she could probably only use her bottom to propel her body and hop, or use her waist and abdominal strength to squat then stand up, then jump forward with both feet together.

But this was extremely difficult.

Xu Qingzhu didn't exercise often, and her constitution was poor. Now with her eyes blindfolded, trapped in a dark and damp place, she kept telling herself in her heart not to be afraid—she was no longer the child she used to be.

But fear still surged up endlessly from the depths of her heart.

She was afraid, terrified. She wanted to escape this environment, wanted to see light, wanted to bask in the sun.

Memories from many years ago kept flooding into her mind, overlapping with the current scene. She gripped her own palm tightly, her fingernails almost digging into the flesh. She hypnotized herself: It's okay, someone will come to save me, the kidnapper won't do anything to me.

It was useless.

The psychological defenses she had built up over so many years were teetering on the verge of collapse. Her reason and emotions were completely at odds.

Xu Qingzhu swallowed. In this quiet environment, even the sound of swallowing was loud—almost louder than her own heartbeat.

Xu Qingzhu didn't dare move anymore, hoping not to be noticed.

But a moment later, something cold landed on her face—like a folding knife.

The cold metallic sensation made her shudder, and stress-induced tears instantly flowed out.

Crystal tears slid down her cheeks. Xu Qingzhu didn't move at all, only hearing a voice say: "Baby, you're awake?"

This voice carried a hint of teasing and a few notes of intimacy.

The way she called someone "baby" was sickeningly sweet, enough to make one want to vomit.

But Xu Qingzhu didn't dare move. The cold metallic sensation kept triggering those memories, but she was trying her best to suppress them, fearing her emotions would collapse.

The saying "long illness makes a doctor"¹ had a certain degree of credibility and feasibility.

After so many years of psychological treatment, Xu Qingzhu could slightly suppress her emotions through self-hypnosis, but she couldn't maintain the same calmness as usual.

That voice sounded in her ear again: "You've been quite pleased with yourself lately."

Xu Qingzhu couldn't speak. Even wanting to question her, she could only make muffled sounds. After trying and finding she couldn't speak, she stopped even making those sounds, not daring to talk to the kidnapper, afraid of direct confrontation.

In this kind of environment, it seemed only sleep could soothe her anxious and frightened heart.

But when one finds oneself in such a dangerous environment, no one can fall asleep.

It was also an abandoned chemical factory—a place where no sunlight could reach, with only one dim yellow light illuminating the enormous factory floor, making it impossible to see clearly.

Several children were huddled together, keeping each other warm.

There were still "troublemakers," there were those who didn't fit in, there were brave ones who "stood out"—but the end result was always the same without exception: death.

That was the kidnapping case from many years ago. Groups of two or three people sat in the factory, smoking and drinking. When they chatted, they spoke in regional dialects, and even when they occasionally spoke Mandarin, it wasn't standard.

They were all dreaming of a wonderful future—what kind of luxurious life they could live after getting the ransom, how many houses they could buy, how many cars, how many wives.

The young children couldn't understand their words, but they could understand the meaning from their non-standard Mandarin.

There were even more outrageous ones who told the people inside to pick a child to take back and raise—once she grew up, she would become a wife.

They discussed those things brazenly in front of the children. Those vulgar and filthy words came out of their mouths all day long.

At first, they too were thrown in a corner, not given food to eat—just a mouthful of cold water.

Even the cold water was shared among several people from one bowl.

One little girl had broken the bowl and was beaten severely, because they accused her of trying to escape this way.

But they forgot that children only a few years old didn't have the strength to untie the knots they had tied.

The reason Xu Qingzhu was afraid of darkness was because those people, after eating and drinking their fill, got bored and played with the kidnapped children like toys.

Her eyes were covered with black cloth, so dark that not a sliver of light could get through.

Someone handed her a knife and told her to stab with it.

In front of her was Liang Shi, holding a foam board in her hands.

Footnotes:

¹ **Long illness makes a doctor (久病成醫):** A Chinese proverb meaning that someone who has been sick for a long time eventually learns enough about their condition to become like a doctor themselves. In this context, it refers to how Xu Qingzhu has learned to manage her psychological condition through years of treatment.

Chapter 124-4

Liang Shi was always smiling, standing out among those children who were trembling with fear.

Even though she was standing there holding a foam board, facing a terrifying threat to her life, her smile never stopped.

One kidnapper was so creeped out by her smile that he kicked her and told her to stop smiling.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, but a moment later she smiled again—just not as wide as before.

Even though her eyes were filled with tears, looking utterly pitiful.

That kidnapper said: "Is this one a fucking idiot?"

Another one said: "What a pity, she's quite pretty too."

Everyone assumed she was an idiot, but she had secretly told Xu Qingzhu: "Life is already hard enough, so we should smile more. As long as we smile more, life will get better."

She would talk to Xu Qingzhu, would comfort Xu Qingzhu in a low voice, would coax Xu Qingzhu not to cry, would pull out White Rabbit milk candies¹ from her own pocket to give to Xu Qingzhu.

She was like a little angel. Back then, Xu Qingzhu thought she was so amazing.

During the days they were held captive there, it wouldn't be an exaggeration to say they depended on each other for survival.

But it was also because the two of them interacted too frequently that they were pulled out by those hateful kidnappers to "play a game."

Their tastes were cruel and bloody. Just the moment she received the knife, Xu Qingzhu was so scared she wanted to cry. That beautiful little face was covered in tears as she timidly called out: "Jiejie..."

Xu Qingzhu's hands were trembling, and the knife slipped from her sweat-drenched hands. Meanwhile, Liang Shi, standing across from her, clearly knew something might happen to her, clearly had her legs shaking with fear, yet still smiled and said: "It's okay, don't be afraid."

As if she were the one holding the knife.

Xu Qingzhu was blindfolded with a cloth strip. Someone gripped her shoulders and guided her toward Liang Shi's direction.

That factory was quiet, damp, filled with the rustling sounds of rats, the disgusting smell of smoke and alcohol, the agonizing sounds of jeering laughter. Most crucially, there was the fear of the unknown.

That fear came from the possibility that she might kill someone, that she might use that knife to hurt someone she was very close to.

She called out in a trembling voice, again and again: "Jiejie... Jiejie..."

Those people laughed even louder. "What a touching display of sisterly love. Then go ahead and stab—let's see if you can stab your dear jiejie."

A knife was forcibly shoved into Xu Qingzhu's tender white little hands. She could feel the cold metallic texture, could even feel the sharpness of the blade—she could hear clearly the sound it made cutting through the air.

As if it could slice through the wind.

This was probably the suffering of having hearing that was too good.

Xu Qingzhu frowned as she moved forward. Her legs seemed to not belong to her anymore; she only knew to walk forward numbly. Her arms had curled back entirely, afraid of stabbing someone.

She tried to keep the knife pointed down as much as possible, but when those people noticed, they grabbed her by the hair.

That pain and humiliation of being bullied hit her in an instant. Even after so many years, she still couldn't forget it.

Back then, she was also blindfolded with cloth strips, unable to see anything, only able to move forward using her good hearing. She was afraid of becoming a murderer, afraid of hurting Liang Shi.

Tears soaked through the black cloth strip, revealing a faint glimmer of light.

Even when she was bullied, she didn't dare cry loudly. She could only bite her lip and sob quietly, because children who cried loudly here would get beaten.

The dilapidated, abandoned old factory was a living hell.

And the moment her hair was grabbed, Liang Shi threw down the foam board and went to hit that person. She was young and didn't have much strength, and having been hungry for so long, she was no match for that man at all. But she showed no fear. When hitting and kicking weren't enough, she used her teeth to bite. When she bit hard enough to make him hurt, he let go and slapped her across the face.

The pitiful little child was bullied there with no ability to resist.

That they could survive at all was a miracle.

After all the commotion, young Xu Qingzhu was blindfolded with the cloth strip again. Her world was pitch black. She called out in a trembling voice: "Jiejie..."

Liang Shi answered: "I'm here. Don't be afraid."

Liang Shi said: "Be a little braver. I'm fine."

.....

Her PTSD started from there.

There are many things that can trigger fear in post-traumatic stress disorder. She had already tried her best to control herself.

But if a condition could be controlled, it wouldn't be called a condition.

No patient would willingly choose to become a patient.

Footnotes:

¹ **White Rabbit milk candies (大白兔奶糖):** A famous Chinese candy brand that has been beloved by generations of Chinese children since the 1940s. These are soft, chewy milk-flavored candies wrapped in edible rice paper, often associated with childhood nostalgia and comfort in China.

Chapter 124-5

Xu Qingzhu's tears fell onto Chen Liuying's hand, even flowing over that sharp knife. Chen Liuying wiped the back of her hand, then curved her lips into a smile: "Baby, you're scared already?"

Xu Qingzhu still couldn't speak.

Seemingly finding it boring to talk to herself, Chen Liuying reached out and ripped the tape off her mouth. But the knife landed by her lips as she said in a strange tone: "Baby, keep your voice down. If you're too loud... I'll get angry, and then my knife might slip across your face. If you're not pretty anymore, I won't like you."

Xu Qingzhu's lips were parched. When the tape was violently ripped off, some dead skin was torn from her lips as well. But when facing a life-threatening situation, this small injury was insignificant.

She asked hoarsely: "What do you want?"

This was already the maximum rationality she could maintain.

The other party laughed: "What I want... is very simple. I just want... you all to DIE!"

By the time she said those last two words, her tone had changed, carrying an indescribable anger.

"Do we have a grudge?" Xu Qingzhu's voice trembled, but her fingers dug tightly into her own palm, trying her best not to be afraid, creating an opportunity for herself to have an equal dialogue with the kidnapper.

But how could she not be afraid?

In this kind of environment, all the frightening memories were triggered. Those memories she thought she had already forgotten were stirred up again, only to find that every scene was so vivid.

She desperately suppressed them... suppressed them...

"You ruined me." Chen Liuying's voice became increasingly strange, tinged with madness. Although she was smiling, she was using the smile to mask her anger: "Baby, you ruined me. My entire life was destroyed by you."

"Do you know how hard I worked to get all that? Do you know how hard I worked to climb above my class? People like you who were born with everything don't understand, but you can so easily destroy all that effort." Chen Liuying pressed the knife closer to her face, inadvertently breaking the skin.

Xu Qingzhu felt a stinging pain on her face and instinctively drew in a sharp breath.

Chen Liuying sneered: "Baby, so you can still feel pain? Oh, I forgot—you're a delicate little princess that no one can touch, provoke, or get close to. So what? Now you're in my hands. I actually quite like you."

The heat from Chen Liuying's breath spilled entirely onto Xu Qingzhu's face.

Xu Qingzhu smelled a strong scent of alcohol.

She only remembered receiving a phone call in her office, saying that flowers had been delivered downstairs. She had thought they were from Liang Shi, and when she received the call, a flash of joy passed through her heart.

It wasn't any special occasion, yet she could receive little romantic gestures from Liang Shi.

Xu Qingzhu hadn't thought too much at the time. She went downstairs without even putting on her coat. Then she received another call saying it was on the other side, so she followed the phone's directions. But just as she turned a corner, something was injected directly into the back of her neck, and she lost consciousness.

She never would have imagined that this person would be so bold as to do such a thing in broad daylight, in such a bustling area.

Xu Qingzhu didn't know where she had been taken, but it should still be within Haizhou City.

She didn't know who the other party was, let alone what they wanted.

She was currently in a state of complete ignorance while facing a threat to her life.

Fundamentally speaking, she and the kidnapper were on unequal footing.

All Xu Qingzhu could do was stall... stall for time.

To see if anyone would notice she was missing, if anyone would come to save her.

"Is this how you show you like someone?" Xu Qingzhu countered lightly, "Why don't I feel any of your affection?"

The other party was momentarily at a loss for words.

A moment later, Chen Liuying directly removed the black cloth covering her eyes. Her eyes could see light again, and her fear wasn't as heavy anymore. Some rationality returned.

When she saw it was Chen Liuying, Xu Qingzhu was only slightly surprised.

What surprised her was that Chen Liuying could kidnap her single-handedly. What was expected was that Chen Liuying would do something this insane.

"You don't seem very surprised." Chen Liuying said, "Do you think I can't see your expression?"

"What expression do you want to see from me?" Xu Qingzhu lowered her brows and eyes: "Anyway, I've already fallen into your hands. What do you want to do? Want money or revenge? Do you want to take revenge on me, or do you want to kill me?"

The earlier words still had some trembling, letting one hear her fear, but the last three words were spoken fearlessly.

Compared to the former, she was very calm about the latter.

But Chen Liuying put away the knife, the motion slow and deliberate. She scoffed: "Baby, how could I bear to kill you?"

Her finger traced along Xu Qingzhu's jawline. Her somewhat long fingernails suddenly pinched lightly on Xu Qingzhu's delicate face. She gripped Xu Qingzhu's chin forcefully, forcing her to raise her head and look at her: "Xu Qingzhu, I want... to let you see how the person you love suffers in agony."

Chen Liuying flung her chin away, nearly dislocating Xu Qingzhu's jaw.

At that moment, Xu Qingzhu even briefly thought with dark humor: Good thing this chin is real.

But when she heard the latter half of that sentence, her expression changed. "Chen Liuying."

Xu Qingzhu called her name very seriously: "What happened back then was my doing. If you want revenge, come to me."

"I refuse." Chen Liuying sat casually on a higher surface, looking down at her from above: "I like to torture people slowly, to let you all experience the pain I felt that day."

Those vicious PR tactics had plunged her from a heart full of joy into an endless abyss.

She would make all these people taste it.

Just as she finished speaking, Xu Qingzhu's phone lit up. Chen Liuying picked up the phone and played the voice message.

It was Liang Shi's voice, panting for breath.

She said: "I'm here. Where are you?"

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu's heart felt inexplicably heavy.

Xu Qingzhu only hoped that Liang Shi's future life would be flowers and red carpets, a broad and smooth path.

All the painful memories could stay vivid in her own mind, becoming indelible marks in her own life.

She thought: Liang Shi, don't remember, don't recall.

—Those embarrassing, dark, painful memories—let them disappear from your life.

—Please, please don't remember them.

Chapter 124-6

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When Liang Shi pushed open the door and entered that dilapidated factory, the iron door let out a dull, creaking sound.

She was soaked through from head to toe, her hair hanging wetly against her body.

She was wearing a set of black loungewear, an utterly ordinary style, but on her it carried its own charm.

That beautiful face was the best filter.

Now with her clothes heavily clinging to her body from the rain, her complexion was deathly pale. With her fairly good eyesight, she spotted Xu Qingzhu inside the factory at a glance.

She immediately ran forward, but was stopped halfway by Chen Liuying's shout: "Stop!"

Chen Liuying's knife was pressed against the side of Xu Qingzhu's neck.

—Rumble.

Deafening thunder roared in an instant. The sky seemed to be torn open by light, flashing a faint brightness that illuminated this dark factory.

Liang Shi's footsteps halted. She immediately said: "I won't move!"

Only then did Chen Liuying stop with satisfaction. She stared at Liang Shi and said eerily: "That PR scheme that day was your doing, right? Hiding behind the internet being a petty person. You two wives really know how to work together."

Liang Shi: "....."

Her face was dripping wet, but she couldn't afford to care about that. Her eyes were fixed tightly on Chen Liuying's knife, terrified that she would stab it in if displeased. She could only placate her: "Yes, all the ideas that day were mine. Because I understand the entertainment industry too well, I know too well how to manipulate online opinion. So I forced Xu Qingzhu to adopt my suggestions. I know you want revenge, but you need to find the right person. What's the use of hurting Xu Qingzhu? The person you should be looking for is me."

She spoke with such conviction, as if Chen Liuying would be an idiot not to come after her.

Afraid that Chen Liuying wouldn't believe her, Liang Shi continued: "Why else would I go into acting? I went precisely because I understand these things. What kind of environment did I grow up in? It was definitely full of scheming and intrigue. Your little tricks are child's play. Xu Qingzhu is just a bookworm who only knows how to study—besides studying, it's just exams. What does she understand? I taught her everything."

"Even when she called Bai Weiwei, I was typing beside her and she just read from the script." Liang Shi said, "Come after me."

Chen Liuying was stunned for a moment, then laughed. "Bai Weiwei said you two had a plastic marriage, a sham marriage, that you didn't like each other at all. I really had to laugh. It seems you two are deeply devoted to each other. That stupid woman Bai Weiwei—after being your bestie for so many years, she still couldn't see what you like."

As Chen Liuying spoke, she moved closer to Xu Qingzhu again. Xu Qingzhu instinctively flinched away.

Chen Liuying laughed: "Then this makes things easier."

She stood up. She wasn't as tall as Liang Shi, but because Liang Shi was completely drenched while she was clean and dry, the contrast between their images was stark. Liang Shi's presence didn't seem as strong as hers.

Liang Shi's deliberate show of weakness put Chen Liuying in a great mood, so when she pulled out another military knife from her pocket, she was smiling. She threw the knife on the ground, and it landed with a clang.

The moment Liang Shi saw the knife, she suddenly remembered that the system had said major events wouldn't change—they wouldn't trigger a huge butterfly effect just because of her arrival.

All major events were bound to happen.

Sure enough, Chen Liuying's next words were: "Pick up that knife and gouge out your glands."

Liang Shi: "....."

After she came to this world, she had made Chen Liuying fall from grace earlier, so Chen Liuying's storyline had been moved up. Originally, it was because of her admiration for Xu Qingzhu that she would gouge out her glands. Now it had become hatred toward herself, so she kidnapped Xu Qingzhu to force her to gouge out her own glands.

Liang Shi didn't really care. She had lived over twenty years without glands; even without glands, it wouldn't affect her much.

She picked up the knife from the ground. "As long as I gouge out my glands, you'll release Xu Qingzhu?"

Since it couldn't be changed, she might as well follow the storyline's development.

Chen Liuying laughed: "That depends on my mood."

Liang Shi cursed her as a dog in her heart, but still pointed the knife at the position of her own glands.

Chen Liuying watched her at leisure, but Xu Qingzhu shouted: "No! Liang Shi!"

Liang Shi smiled at her. "Xu Qingzhu, don't be afraid."

She always loved saying those words: "Don't be afraid," "I'm here"—as if as long as she was there, she could help fend off all difficulties.

That familiar feeling struck again. Xu Qingzhu's tears were like a switch had been flipped, flowing endlessly down her face. Her voice was choked: "Liang Shi... don't..."

Don't do this, I'm begging you.

I already owe you too much.

"Jiejie..." Xu Qingzhu called out to her with a choked voice, "Don't hurt yourself..."

Liang Shi's knife landed on the back of her own neck. The blade was sharp, and the moment it touched down, beads of blood nearly emerged.

But a moment later, Liang Shi let go. She looked at Chen Liuying: "I can't do it."

Liang Shi showed weakness: "I'm a coward with no real abilities. I really can't do it. You do it..."

Liang Shi said: "You can tie me up and do it, otherwise I'll struggle... Besides, isn't revenge something you should do yourself? You gouging out my glands with your own hands is much better than watching me do it myself."

Chen Liuying wavered slightly. "Really?"

Liang Shi said helplessly: "Xu Qingzhu is still in your hands—can I lie? If someone told you to gouge out your own glands right now, you'd be too scared of the pain to do it too. I'm this much of a coward; I simply can't do it, and I'd probably gouge the wrong spot anyway. You do it yourself."

Chen Liuying gave a cold snort. "Who knows what tricks you're playing."

Liang Shi said aggrievedly: "How could I? You've at least had training. Someone like me usually just focuses on living it up—how could I be more capable than you? It's not like you haven't heard Bai Weiwei talk about me..."

Liang Shi kept showing weakness to make Chen Liuying lower her guard.

Seeing her attitude soften somewhat, Liang Shi added a final dose: "If you do it, you can control how deep it goes. If I do it myself, I'll just barely touch it, and you definitely won't be happy."

The moment she finished speaking, Chen Liuying strode toward Liang Shi with large steps, a bloodthirsty gleam flickering in her eyes.

Liang Shi threw the knife on the ground and stood there empty-handed, her light brown eyes staring straight at Chen Liuying.

Chen Liuying picked up the military knife. As she bent down to pick it up, Liang Shi seized the moment to press down on her spine, flipping her over on the ground. She wrapped her legs around Chen Liuying's body and pinned her down with absolute force.

...Gouge out her glands? Dream on.

If Liang Shi gouged out her glands, her combat ability would definitely be greatly reduced, and there was no telling how Chen Liuying might bully Xu Qingzhu then.

Better to take the gamble.

Her mind was highly focused, but Chen Liuying was no pushover either. After sensing the danger, she desperately struggled free of Liang Shi's grip. Meanwhile, Liang Shi's nape was stinging from earlier, and coupled with the fact that she already had a slight fever, her movements weren't as agile as usual.

In the blink of an eye, Chen Liuying's knife landed on the side of her neck.

Aimed directly at the position of her glands...